31. In West Asia, naturally wild vegetation no longer occurs in clearly defined zones but is dispersed in small areas. The region is predominantly arid; desertlike depressions such as the Kyzylkum Desert of Uzbekistan and Kazakhstan, the Karakum Desert of Turkmenistan, and the Rub' al-Khali (Empty Quarter) of the Arabian Peninsula contrast with the moist, forested mountains that lie between them.
32. Three climatic zones, however, characterise West Asia: a continental climate in the northern regions; a dry zone, except where northerly winds bring moisture to the mountains, to the south; and a Mediterranean climate along the western edges. A fringe of steppe covers the area between the Fertile Crescent (which sweeps in an arc from the Tigris-Euphrates valley to the Mediterranean) and the north and west of the Syrian Desert.
33. Areas with some of the least-disturbed ecosystems occur in northern and eastern Siberia, the Plateau of Tibet, and the mountain ranges of Central Asia. By contrast, areas exhibiting some of the most drastic changes to natural conditions include the eastern margins of the Thar (Great Indian) Desert in South Asia, Inner Mongolia and the Ordos region in China—all of which have been subject to intensive desertification from livestock overgrazing —and the Aral Sea basin in Middle Asia.
34. Statement 1: CORRECT—The Aral Sea basin is in Middle Asia. Large-scale irrigation for cotton cultivation reduced the flow of the Amu Darya and Syr Darya, which feed the sea, and thus severely reduced its area.
    Statement 2: CORRECT—A toxic mixture of salts and pesticide residue from the dried seafloor has been spread by dust storms throughout the region.
35. Statement 1: INCORRECT—Most of the Melanesian region is in the Southern Hemisphere, with a few small northwestern islands of Western New Guinea in the Northern Hemisphere.
    Statement 2: CORRECT